BÓYÌ 博弈 · WEEK 16

yù qín gù zòng

欲擒故纵

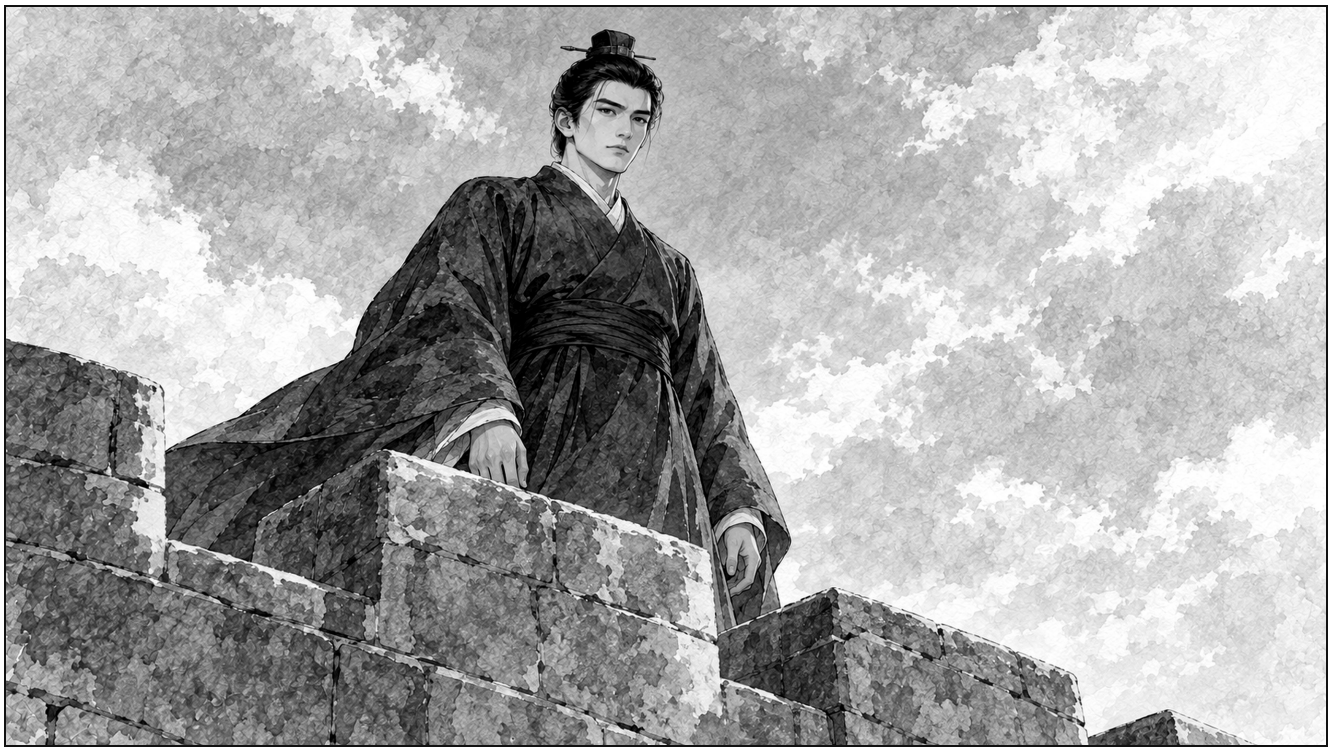
Let him go, to catch him.

A duke had two sons. Their mother loved the younger one. She asked for the younger to be the heir. The father refused. When the elder took the throne, she asked for a city for her favourite. He gave her Jing. Then he repaired walls, sharpened arms, and set a date. The earl heard the date. He said: now. This week you'll learn to write four characters: 欲, 擒, 故, 纵.

Stratagem No. 16 of 36 · one story, one lesson, four characters.

本周学：欲擒故纵 · 练字：欲、擒、故、纵

SHE ASKED FOR A CITY



His brother moved in, called himself the Great Uncle of Jing.

Zuo Zhuan says this happened over two thousand seven hundred years ago. A duke had two sons. Their mother loved the younger one.

She asked for the younger to be the heir. The father refused.

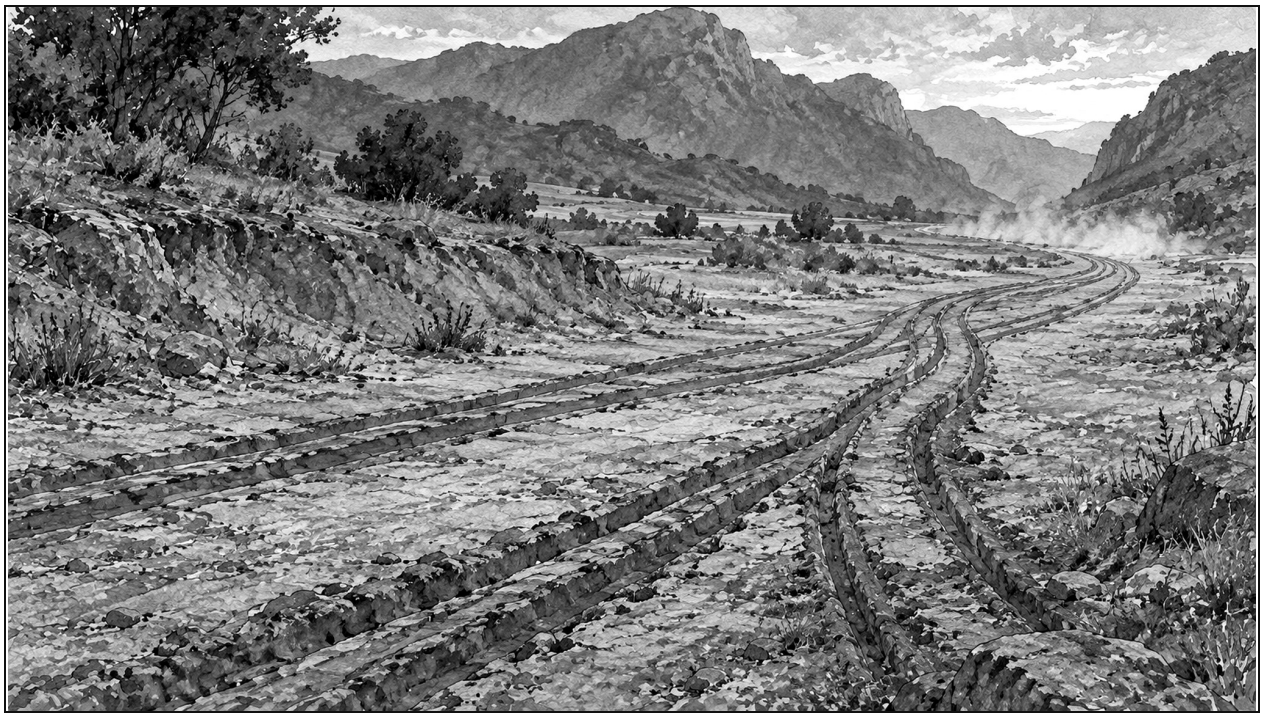
When the elder took the throne, she asked for a city for her favourite. She named the strongest city. He said: anywhere but that. So she asked for Jing. He gave her Jing.

A minister measured the wall. A city that big is not allowed. The earl said: my mother wants it.

The minister said: she is never full. Stop it early. The earl said: he keeps doing wrong. He will bring himself down. Wait.

《左传·隐公元年》（郑伯克段于鄢）

HE SAID: NOW



Not caught. Not killed. Gone.

Another minister said: one state, two masters. Give all or take him down. The earl said: no need. He will reach it.

The minister said: now. He is too big. The earl said: wrong things do not hold. The bigger, the faster it falls.

Their mother would open a gate for him from inside. The earl heard the date. He said: now.

Two hundred chariots went out. Jing turned on its own lord. His brother ran to Yan. The army followed. He ran again, to Gong.

There the story stops. Not caught. Not killed. Gone. So he was not cornered. He had waited. That is the stratagem: let him walk, follow, do not push.

《左传·隐公元年》（郑伯克段于鄢）

WHY IT WORKED

Step	Move	中文 · pinyin	Result
First	push him	逼 bī	He pushes back
Second	let him go	走 zǒu	His force drains
Third	follow, do not press	随 suí	They scatter

逼他，他会反扑；放他走，气势会掉；跟着他但别逼，等他散了再收。 欲擒故纵 yù qín gù zòng

THE ORIGINAL LINES

《三十六计·第十六计 欲擒故纵》

The Thirty-Six Stratagems, No. 16 — "Let him go, to catch him"

1

bī zé fǎn bīng; zǒu zé jiǎn shì

逼则反兵；走则减势。

First: push him, he pushes back. Second: let him go, his force drains.

2

jǐn suí wù pò; lěi qí qì lì

紧随勿迫。累其气力，

Third: follow him. Do not press. Wear him down.

3

xiāo qí dòu zhì; sàn ér hòu qín

消其斗志，散而后擒，

When they scatter, take them.

4

bīng bù xuè rèn; xū yǒu fú guāng

兵不血刃。需，有孚，光。

The last five words are older.

Thirty-two characters. All of them about distance.

原文三十二字，说的全是距离。最后四字「需，有孚，光。」出自更早的《易经》，本集不解释。

PRACTICE · 欲 YÙ · 擒 QÍN

Follow the numbers. Write each stroke in order.

先描一遍分解格，再在田字格里写 5 遍。

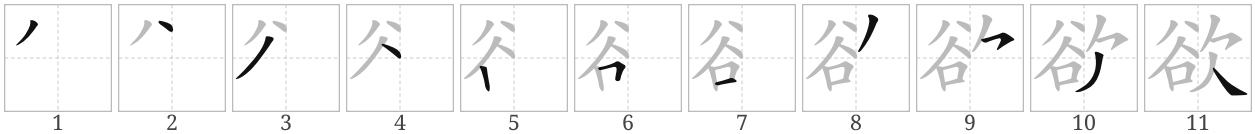
欲

yù

to want

11 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN

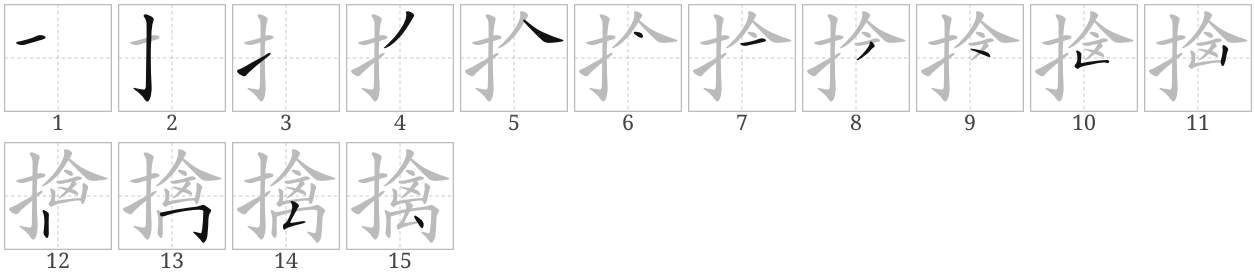
擒

qín

to catch

15 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN

PRACTICE · 故 GÙ · 纵 ZÒNG

Same order again. Write slowly, and say the sound out loud.

写完 4 个字，再回到第 7 页连写整句。

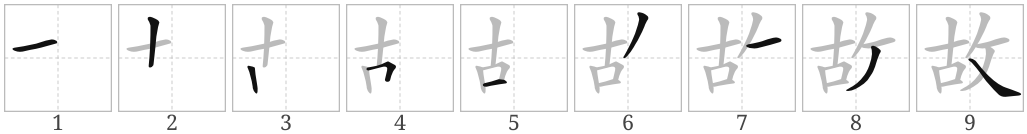
故

gù

on purpose

9 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN

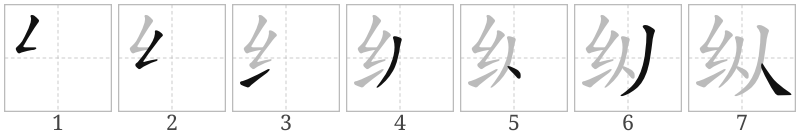
纵

zòng

to let go

7 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN

PRACTICE · 欲擒故纵 YÙ QÍN GÙ ZÒNG

Trace the first row, then write the whole phrase four times. Say it out loud each time.

yù	qín	gù	zòng
欲	擒	故	纵

欲擒故纵 · Let him go, to catch him.

THREE MORE WORDS

bī

1 逼

to push; to corner.

bī tā tā huì fǎn pū

逼他，他会反扑。

Push him and he turns on you.

Do not push him into a corner.

---

suí

2 随

to follow.

gēn zài tā hòu miàn bié tì tā fú fāng xiàng pán

跟在他后面，别替他扶方向盘。

Stay behind them. Do not hold the wheel.

Follow, but do not steer.

---

děng

3 等

to wait.

kě yǐ děng bù néng shè tào

可以等，不能设套。

You can wait. You cannot set him up.

Waiting is not doing nothing.

SPOT IT · STOP IT 识破 · 防住

Back to that meeting. The list is on the screen. Twelve items. Not one of them is new. Each one happened months ago. You could have asked: is this okay?

等
Wait: the step is his

gěi kōng jiān
给 空 间
Give room

gēn zhe
跟 着
Follow, do not press

tā zì jǐ zhuàng qiáng
他 自 己 撞 墙
He hits the wall

设套
Set him up: you pay

xiān dòng shǒu
先 动 手
You move first

biān yì tiáo
编 一 条
Invent one item

zhàng huí zì jǐ
账 回 自 己
The bill comes back

Two ways to handle someone going too far. Wait: the step is his, and so is the bill. Set him up: you move first, and you pay. One is patience. One is a trap.

一个人越走越远，有两种处理法。等：那一步是他自己走的，账算在他头上。设套：你先动了手，同一张账单回来找你。一种是耐心，一种是陷阱。

SEVEN DAYS, SEVEN QUESTIONS

Day 1 Who on your team keeps breaking small rules — and what have you said out loud? 规则 guī zé

Day 2 What did your silence last month look like permission for? 沉默 chén mò

Day 3 Which mistake did you punish too late — and why the delay? 太晚 tài wǎn

Day 4 Where are you pushing so hard that the other side pushes back? 逼 bī

Day 5 What would 'give room, not a hole' look like this week? 空间 kōng jiān

Day 6 Whose growth are you slowing by stepping in too early? 让开 ràng kāi

Day 7 Which step did you take yourself that you could have let them take? 让他 ràng tā

WEEK 16 REVIEW



The one-page summary of this week. 本周一图总结。

1. In one sentence: what did the earl wait for?

2. What does 欲擒故纵 mean, in your own words?

3. Which of this week's four characters can you write now without looking: 欲, 擒, 故, or 纵?

4. Where did you punish too late something you could have stopped on day one?

You can wait. You cannot set him up.
可以等，不能设套。
Nǐ kě yǐ děng, bù néng shè tào.

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